

Equality and computer science

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The majority of those studying and working in computer science are white, able-bodied males. What is the reason for this, and can computer science become more diverse?

Women and computing

The role women have played in the development of computer science has often been downplayed. In the early days of computer science, most programmers were women. Ada Lovelace, the first programmer, was a woman, and the team that coded the Electronic Numerical Integrator And Computer (ENIAC) in the 1940s was entirely female.



◀ Less than a quarter

In modern times, women occupy less than a quarter of the worldwide jobs in the computer science industry. This is generally called the “gender gap”.

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Women “computers” who did complex mathematical calculations by hand, along with female programmers, were heavily involved in America’s space programme in the 1960s. At NASA, they were part of the team that calculated flight paths for space probes and several Apollo rockets. American computer scientist Margaret Hamilton (b. 1936) led the team that programmed the on-board flight computer for the first Moon landing.



Why is there a gender gap?

The number of women studying computing or going into programming as a profession began to drop dramatically in the mid-1980s. One explanation for this is the decision of computer companies at the time to pitch computers as gaming devices, and to target computers and games at males. This resulted in girls being given the impression that computing was “for boys”. There are other possible reasons for the gender gap.

▷ Perceptions

Computer science is perceived as being a technical subject and, wrongly, one that naturally better suits males. Lack of encouragement makes it hard, particularly for teenage girls, to take part in an activity that is seen as unfeminine, and in which they’re outnumbered.

